



Some of the older movies had it right. Ferris Bueller's day off uses some low-tech hardware for a social engineering approach to get a day off from school

key. After the scam is done, the best way to dispose of this odd device that no one will suspect of being incriminating? Throw it in the trash can. Haven't these guys ever heard of dumpster diving?

Primer

This movie is full of jargon from the Principles of Quantum Mechanics text book. Some of the hardware shown in the movie was really strange - a switch-board of around twenty switches, marked



There is something going on here that we don't know about

by single alphabets with something like five wires coming out of it. There must be some interesting permutation/combination mechanisms here, but that was never really explained. We are sure someone actually working with whatever hokey brand of science the movie portrays would punch holes in all the complicated dialogues. We'll pick a simple one that everyone knows. Russians never used a pencil to write in space, underwater or upside down. For those who believed that the NASA guys were suckers for spending a bomb on a pen that could do all that, bear in mind how easy it is for pencil marks to fade.

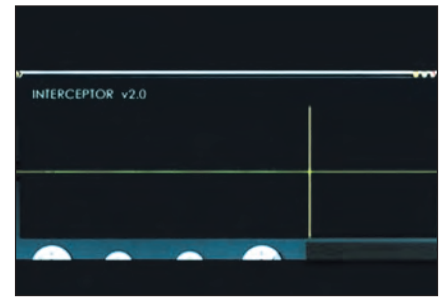
Swordfish

One really bad-ass guy threatens one really talented hacker to break into a US

Department of Defense console protected with 128-bits of encryption. The machine is something like a laptop that has a login screen. Now what Jobson the hacker does with the machine is really incredible. The login screen just disappears, as he tries a number of ways to... bypass the login screen. Apparently the world's best crackers can beat the encryption in under an hour. Not true, never been done, and never will be. The universe will never last long enough to decrypt that level of encryption as long as procedures are followed. Crackers have managed to circumvent specific implementation of the encryption though, and Jobson manages to do it, with a few dozen random keystrokes, and totally irrelevant text scrolling on the screen. The last time we checked, such hacks mostly involved giving a few commands and waiting. Actually, getting a USB drive full of magical software, and clicking a button would have been so much more real. The movie makes it look like you give a really good hacker enough money (and other incentives), then hacking takes no time whatsoever, which is just not true in real life. Hackers have to distribute work over a network to break a 64-bit key, the 512-bit one in the movie would keep all the biggest botnets in the world busy for a few millennia. Swordfish even takes us back to the old Ghost in the Machine days for a while, with a few glorious seconds of flying through cyberspace and tracking wires. Must watch for the long, animated demo on how to compile a worm.

A Wednesday

The operating systems in this movie seem to have a magical interface that can be controlled mentally. With almost no related



The Interceptor doing its thing

input, they figure out what is going on in the plot, and decide to take the appropriate actions. The Windows pop up on their own, showing the random text and icons whenever possible, and at strategic timings, a search bar, a voice waveform or a box that says "untraceable" keeps showing up. Most of the software in the movie, for example, Interceptor v2.0 don't even have an interface of any kind, no buttons, no console, just a window that gives all the output that you might want. We really wish technology were this magical. Apart from the interfaces, the depiction of technology in this movie was pretty accurate.

Live Free or Die Hard

This is another movie that suffers from the blue screen syndrome, where most of the terminals prefer to show information only in blue. The operating System used in this



Ooh, so many buttons, this must be complicated

movie is really strange sometimes, there are just the readouts without any input options or buttons available, and pop-ups from a browser window seem to show up from all the sides, instead of just one direction. What really takes the cake is the simple software based control over all kinds of grids in America that exists. One guy with access to a system can apparently send gas down any direction in a pipeline. **d**



Some things are, last time we checked like cracking 512 bit encryption faster than it takes to put in the password